

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Illuminated: A Cinematic Journey to Deeper Spirituality
Making Way for Tomorrow, Loving for Today
March 2nd, 2025



Photographer Unknown

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Improvisation on MEDEMA and HYFRYDOL
Voluntary on DIX (Robert Lind) and Improvisation
Pergolesi Paraphrases: *Stabat Mater* Part 2
Who Are These Like Stars Appearing? (Paul Fejko)
Fugue in Eb Major, BWV 552/2 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman, Emily Kang, and Nathaniel Martin

Words of Gathering

Betsy Sullenger & Chambers Stevens

This light which bathes the world, pours from a source so close,
so near, and yet we cannot touch it or fence it in that it not be lost.

This light, which shatters the deepest shadows, is pierced together, flame by flame,
shining from a thousand sources but is diminished by the loss of one.

This light which fills the furthest corner brings with it warmth
to fill billions of hearts and bind them with a common truth.

This light which pulls us toward tomorrow is carried deep within each of our hearts
and lit by you and me and they and all who live upon this earth.

This light which is yours and mine to carry burns in the love filled heart,
the source of all our inspiration and all the beauty that will ever come to be.

Let it shine!

Please stand now in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering.**

God, Whose Love is Always Stronger

HYFRYDOL

God whose love is always stronger
Than our weakness, pride and fear,
In your world, we pray and wonder
How to be more faithful here.
Hate too often grows inside us;
Fear rules what the nations do.
So we pray, when life divides us:
Give us love, God!
Make us new!

Love is patient, kind and caring.
Never arrogant or rude,
Never boastful, all things bearing;
Love rejoices in the truth.
When we're caught up in believing
We will never live in peace,
Show us Jesus' way of living;
May our strength in you increase.

May our faith in you be nourished;
May all people hear your call.
May our lives be filled with courage
As we speak your grace for all.
Now emboldened by your Spirit
Who has given us new birth,
Give us love, that we may share it
Till your love renews the earth.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Holy One,
Light of all healing:
Be present with us.
Rooted in your love,
May we be.
Filled with your peace,
May we be.
Illumined by your grace,
May we be.

Kindle our hearts
into quiet strength.
Calm our spirits
into restoration.

*Then, O God,
restore the love and joy of our hearts,
on this day, and in all the days to come.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

"One Love"

BOB MARLEY

First Kids First and Cathedral Choir, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

***The Lord's Prayer**

Betsy Sullenger

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.*

*Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

We pause in our busy lives on this day
as we join with others across our globe,
who, like us, yearn for peace;
who, like us, yearn for the day
when all people
live together in harmony and understanding.
We also pause to celebrate the joy of people coming together,
serving one another with common goals and concerns,
helping each other find our way,
sheltering those who need our help,
feeding those hungry for food and love,
and offering our very best for our children
and all the children of our world.

We pause in these moments to give thanks to God for grace,
and ask for God's peace to be with us
in this time together, as we acknowledge
and honor the Divine in each of us with this greeting.

This morning, may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition *from the Gospel of John*

Chambers Stevens

"I give you a new commandment:
Love one another.
And you're to love one another
the way I have loved you.
This is how all will know that you're my disciples:
that you truly love one another."

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

God of Peace and Love, we pause on this day
to remember the world that forged the path
on which we travel,
even as we lean into the hopes
and blank canvases of tomorrow.

Equip us with patience as we view
the landscape of our lives
and continue to dream and plan
this year unfolding before us.
Empower us, O God, with wisdom
as we respond to the challenges
that rise up before us.

Embolden us to speak truth
where distortions litter the way
around us.

Comfort us when we are wearied by the world
and need shelter from its barbs.
Heal us when the wounds we receive limit and hinder us.
Delight with us when there is cause for celebration.
Implant in us a hunger for your justice.
Anchor in us a longing for your love.
Inspire us to spread the colors of your
glorious palette throughout the lives
that intersect with ours.

Temper our anger with discernment,
and redirect our egos away from
self-serving decisions.

And in all things, O God,
ground us in the light and love and peace
that is your being, that we may set forth
into these days with confidence and conviction,
believing in the future that
we are co-creating with you,
and with each other.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"Maria, Dulce, Maria"
Molly Pease, Soloist

FRANCESCA CACCINI

"Mary, sweet Mary, whose name is so lovely, that to utter it takes your heart to Paradise. Sacred and holy name, you inflame my heart with celestial love. 'Mary,' I ever sing, neither can my tongue deliver any happier word than when I say, 'Mary.' Name which tempers and consoles every sorrow, calm voice which assuages every disquiet, which composes every heart, which gladdens every soul."

Sermon

Making Way for Tomorrow, Loving for Today

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

"Jubilant Day"
Cathedral Choir, Molly Pease, Soloist

JUDY A. ROSE

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Betsy Sullenger

Loving Creator of all that is,
you told us that to love you,
our neighbors, and ourselves,
was to live a life of joy.

Created by Love, surrounded by Love,
and made whole by Love,
we are, O God, made in your image.

With this understanding help us
to receive your hope and free us from fear,
as you take our hands and lead us
to love others as you have loved us.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin

Blessed are you
who bear the light
in unbearable times,
who testify
to its endurance
amid the unendurable,
who bear witness
to its persistence
when everything seems
in shadow
and grief.
Blessed are you
in whom
the light lives,
in whom
the brightness blazes—
your heart
a chapel,
an altar where
in the deepest night
can be seen
the fire that
shines forth in you...
in unaccountable faith,
in stubborn hope,
in love that illuminates
every broken thing
it finds.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"Song of Brigid"
Cathedral Choir

LAURA ASH

***Hymn for the Journey**

There's a Spirit of Love in This Place

MEDEMA

There's a spirit of love in this place,
There's a spirit of love in this place.
You can't see it, but it's there, just as precious as the air.
There's a spirit of love in this place.
O Alleluia, sing alleluia!
We bless your holy name, we bless your name.
O Alleluia, sing alleluia!
There's a spirit of love in this place.

There's a presence of peace in this room,
There's a presence of peace in this room.
In God's tenderness is found peace that passes human bounds.
There's a presence of peace in this room.
O Alleluia, sing alleluia!
We bless your holy name.
O Alleluia, sing alleluia!
There's a presence of peace in this room.

-Mark A. Miller

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Who Are These Like Stars Appearing? - Reprise (Paul Fejko)

Inside The Music

"In March we feature many of the women composers that we enjoy all year long as we celebrate Women's History Month. Francesca Caccini was one of the most celebrated composers of her time, which is saying something given that women represented a tiny portion of the composers during her time. She was also the daughter of Giulio Caccini, who is given credit for writing the first opera. Francesca, incidentally, is given credit for being the first woman to write an opera. During the early Baroque era, most women who wanted a professional musical presence became nuns. A nun didn't have to do what their husband told them, and all convents needed music. Francesca had early fame as a performer and composer. Her first husband died soon after they married, and her second husband loved music and supported her continued industry. Although she couldn't participate in the same way in performance due to rules of nobility, she continued to make music. After her second husband died, she returned to her first post with the famed Medici family. Her music represents the florid, text-illuminating compositions of the time, and are some of the more representative early Baroque Italian pieces. Her love of dramatic music reveals itself in her love of narrative, and the ways she aligns text and music. I like "Maria, Dolce, Maria" for today because of that dramatic drive. Caccini takes a sacred text and infuses it with meaning. A few examples include the way she floats the first notes on Mary's name, giving the singer a chance to sing a sweet, deep affection. At the end of the first phrase, the word "paradise" leaps with joy on a long melisma before dropping into "heart" on the same long, sweet notes she used for "Maria." From the start, it sounds as much like a love song as a sacred hymn to the Virgin. This blending of human experience with religious reflection invites us to consider the divine within us, and our relationship therein. We sing Judy Rose's music often, and have enjoyed "Jubilant Day" on multiple occasions. She, too, invites us into relationship with the divine, asking us to walk through the open door of our personal experience. She told me the story of the writing of the piece, telling me that after fearing for her life at the hands of an angry driver, she decided to create art instead of fear. She sat down and wrote the opening phrase "each day begins and ends with me." "Jubilant Day" is an anthem to love and perseverance. It brings together thoughts of the future with thoughts of today, embracing a temporal universality as encouragement." ~ Dr. David Harris